

How to Adult

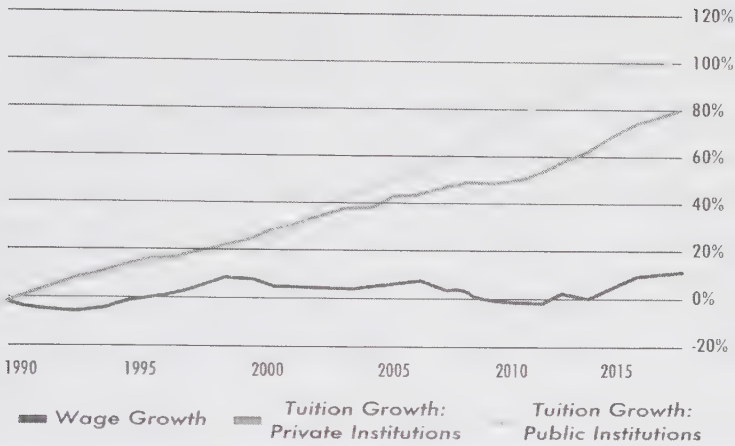


Figure 3.1. U.S. wage growth versus tuition growth, 1990–2018

Sources: "Average undergraduate tuition and fees and room and board rates charged for full-time students in degree-granting postsecondary institutions, by level and control of institution: Selected years, 1963–64 through 2018–19," National Center for Education Statistics, December 2019, https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/d19/tables/dt19_330.10.asp."

Real Median Household Income in the United States," Federal Reserve Bank of Saint Louis, last modified September 10, 2019, <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/MEHOINUSA672N>.

If these statistics don't drive home the importance of your college decision, visit www.studentdebtcrisis.org to read personal anecdotes of people whose financial lives have been devastated by their hefty student loans.

Despite these intimidating numbers, getting a college degree still generally leads to a higher income. As of 2019 the average college graduate earned \$78,000 a year, while someone with only a high school education pulled in an average of \$45,000 a year.¹²

¹² Jason R. Abel and Richard Deitz, "Despite Rising Costs, College Is Still a Good Investment," *Liberty Street Economics*, Federal Reserve Bank of New York, June 5, 2019, <https://libertystreeteconomics.newyorkfed.org/2019/06/despite-rising-costs-college-is-still-a-good-investment.html>.